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PRESERVATION PERIOD OF RECORDS

DISCLAIMER: *This booklet has been prepared strictly from an examination point of view. While every effort has been made to ensure accuracy and the inclusion of recent changes, amendments, and updates to the relevant Acts, Rules, and Regulations, this document is intended as a study aid only. Readers and students are strongly recommended to refer to official government sources or gazettes for the most reliable and authoritative information.*

PRESERVATION PERIOD OF RECORDS

Understanding the exact preservation periods of departmental records is a critical component of daily postal operations and constitutes highly testable material for departmental competitive examinations. Proper record management ensures regulatory compliance, seamless audits, and adherence to established legal frameworks.

These structured notes provide a comprehensive, chronological breakdown of the retention schedules governing various Postal records/registers/documents.

Key areas covered in this material include:

- Savings Bank (SB) Records: Account opening forms, KYC documents, silent account ledgers, and claim cases.
- Mail & Sorting Branch: Franking machine ledgers, mail lists, and bag account reports.
- Accounts & Sub Accounts: Cash books, pay bills, GPF statements, and expenditure records.
- Miscellaneous: Disciplinary proceedings, service books, and standing orders.

The compilation progresses from records requiring immediate destruction to those preserved for extended durations and those retained permanently, enabling systematic understanding and quick revision.

Mastering these preservation schedules establishes a strong foundation for administrative accuracy, audit preparedness, and departmental examination success.

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Variable / Immediate

Branch	Description of Records	Period of Preservation
Savings Bank	Specimen signature books - HO	To be destroyed forthwith by Postmaster after ensuring that the application forms pertaining to all accounts pending in the books have been prepared
Miscellaneous	Postal and other publications	After supply of new editions
Miscellaneous	Circulars containing instructions of a permanent nature and bearing distinguishing title "Standing Orders"	On specific instructions from competent authority

One Year

Branch	Description of Records	Period of Preservation
Mail and Shorting Branch	All records of mail department except those mentioned in item 1 above and elsewhere in this part	1 year
Accounts	Monthly statements of fluctuating charges in form A	1 year
Accounts	Inspection reports from the Audit Office/Accounts Office	1 year after the next inspection provided all the items have been settled
Accounts	Correspondence relating to fund deduction etc	1 year
Accounts	Gazetted Officer's Pay Slips	1 year
Accounts	Charge Reports (office copies)	1 year
Accounts	Records relating to adjustment of missing credits in GPF accounts	1 year

Accounts	Records relating to final withdrawal from GPF, eg for house building, higher technical education of children etc	1 year
Accounts	GPF annual statements	1 year
Accounts	Register of Sanctioned Establishment	At the end of one year after new one has been prepared
Miscellaneous	Service records of ED agents	1 year from the date of termination of service
Miscellaneous	Inspection reports and verification reports by executive	1 year after the next inspection provided all the items have been settled
Miscellaneous	Correspondence relating to robberies, thefts, frauds, tampering with or loss of registered and parcel mail articles and prosecutions	1 year after the cases are closed
Miscellaneous	OTA records	1 year from the end of the financial year to which forms relate

1.5 Years (18 Months)

Branch	Description of Records	Period of Preservation
Sub Accounts	Sub Office daily accounts	18 months
Sub Accounts	Sub office summaries	18 months
Sub Accounts	Branch Office summaries	18 months
Sub Accounts	Sub Office slips	18 months
Accounts	Remittance advice and acknowledgement	18 months

Accounts	Correspondence relating to losses, defalcations etc	18 months after final orders have been passed (one year in the case of Post Offices and Railway Mail Service Offices)
Savings Bank	Stock register of passbooks	18 months
Savings Bank	SB slip (SB.27)	18 months
Savings Bank	Duplicate copies of preliminary receipts (SB.26) received from the branch offices and kept in the account office	18 months
Savings Bank	Identity slips (counter foils) of Post Office Savings Certificates	18 months after the discharge of the certificates
Savings Bank	Journals of certificates issued and discharged	18 months
Savings Bank	Monthly summaries of certificates issued and discharged	18 months
Miscellaneous	Records relating to issue of Identity Cards	1-1/2 years after the expiry of the validity of the cards
Miscellaneous	Book of Postmarks (MS.18)	1-1/2 years

Two Years

Branch	Description of Records	Period of Preservation
Mail and Shorting Branch	Mail Lists received and despatched	2 years
Mail and Shorting Branch	Register showing payment of advance rentals and postage in respect of hired Franking Machines (FM.16)	2 years
Mail and Shorting Branch	Despatch slips (to accompany each consignment for franked postal articles tendered for despatch) (FM.11)	2 years

Mail and Shorting Branch	Franking Machine daily docket (FM.12)	2 years
Mail and Shorting Branch	List of Licences of Franking Machines authorised to post their articles - to be maintained in the post offices (FM.3)	2 years after expiry of validity date of licence
Mail and Shorting Branch	Franking Machine Record Book (to be maintained by the Main PO and the licensee) (FM.4)	-do-
Mail and Shorting Branch	Franking Machine Ledger to be maintained in the Main Post Office (FM.5)	-do-
Mail and Shorting Branch	Licence for Franking Machine (FM.7)	-do-
Mail and Shorting Branch	Franking Machine Window Ticket (FM.8)	-do-
Bag Account	Day bag book in UBOS/DBOS	2 years
Bag Account	Annexure C (Bag balance reports)	2 years
Bag Account	Due bag lists	2 years
Bag Account	Register showing the closing balances in UBOS/DBOS	2 years
Bag Account	Register showing the bags exchanged with mails between Circles	2 years
Bag Account	Records pertaining to physical verification of bags	2 years
Sub Accounts	Branch office daily accounts	2 years
Sub Accounts	Branch Office Slips	2 years
Accounts	Daily lists of telephone revenue collections	2 years
Accounts	Statement of monthly progressive expenditure and correspondence relating to discrepancy in figures	2 years

Savings Bank	Guard books containing letters pledging deposits in the PO security deposit accounts	Letter of pledge may be retained for two years after the pledge has either been released or the account has been closed
Savings Bank	Register of undeliverable passbooks	2 years after all the pass books entered in the register have been transferred to SBCO
Savings Bank	Guard file containing applications for local transfer of accounts	2 years
Savings Bank	Index to preliminary receipts (MS.15)	2 years
Savings Bank	SB voucher list (SB.22)	2 years
Savings Bank	Objection register (SB.61)	2 years after all the objections have been settled
Savings Bank	Register showing the number of SB passbooks received for entry of interest	2 years
Savings Bank	Register of collection cheques	2 years
Savings Bank	Stock register of SB cheque books	2 years
Savings Bank	Register of returned cheques	2 years
Savings Bank	Register of sanctions issued to Branch Offices and ED Sub Offices in respect of withdrawals exceeding the powers of BPMS/EDSPMS	2 years
Savings Bank	Guard book containing letters of authority from illiterate or blind depositors for operating the accounts through agents	2 years after all the accounts in the guard book have been closed or transferred
Savings Bank	Guard book containing Court orders regarding guardianship of minors	2 years after accounts in the guard book have been closed or transferred

Savings Bank	Guard book containing powers of attorney	2 years after accounts in the guard book have been closed or transferred
Savings Bank	Guard book containing applications for change in the name of SB depositors	2 years after the accounts are closed
Savings Bank	Guard book containing Court attachment orders of SB deposits	2 years after the accounts are closed
Savings Bank	Guard book containing applications of depositors for issue of SB cheque books	2 years after the accounts are closed
Savings Bank	Guard book containing copies of lists of collection cheques on outstation branches	2 years following the financial year to which the guard book belongs...
Savings Bank	Guard book containing copies of lists of collection cheques on local branches	-do-
Savings Bank	Guard book containing copies of lists of collection cheques received from outstation for collection	-do-
Savings Bank	Receipt book for passbooks (SB.28)	2 years
Savings Bank	List of documents	2 years
Savings Bank	Long Books	2 years
Miscellaneous	Enumeration Returns (MS.6)	2 years
Miscellaneous	Confidential records/character sheets of officials who have died	2 years after death

Three Years

Branch	Description of Records	Period of Preservation
Mail and Shorting Branch	Register to be maintained by the counter PA operating Multi Value Franking Machine (FM.1)	3 years from the date of last entry
Mail and Shorting Branch	Franking Machine Register regarding postings (to be maintained by licensee) (FM.10)	3 years from the date of last entry in the register
Sub Accounts	Head Office Summary	3 years
Sub Accounts	Sub Office Accounts	3 years
Sub Accounts	Branch Office Accounts	3 years
Accounts	Head Office Cash Book	3 years
Accounts	Contingent Bills (copies)	3 years
Accounts	Schedule of receipts and payments (copies)	3 years
Accounts	Counterfoils of pay orders	3 years from the date of issue of last pay order
Accounts	Objection statements and retrenchment memoranda	3 years
Accounts	Receipts for money paid (other than those filed with the acquittance rolls)	3 years
Accounts	Correspondence relating to sanctions and revision of establishments etc	3 years...
Accounts	Papers relating to grant of advances of pay, travelling allowances, purchase of motor cars etc	3 years
Accounts	Last pay certificates	3 years

Accounts	Renewal of sanctions to temporary	3 years
Accounts	Receipts and invoices with the exception of those under dispute	3 years
Accounts	Demands for Licence Fee, etc on departmental buildings	3 years
Accounts	Contingent Sub Vouchers	3 years
Accounts	Expenditure sanctions not covered by paragraph 11...	3 years or one year after completion of audit, whichever is later
Accounts	Arrear claims (including sanction for investigation, where necessary)	3 years or one year after completion of audit, whichever is later
Accounts	Records relating to contingent expenditure	3 years or one year after completion of audit, whichever is later
Accounts	Budget estimates/revised estimates of an office	3 years
Accounts	Travelling allowance bills and Acquittance Rolls relating thereto	3 years
Accounts	Service Book (including leave account)	3 years after death/retirement or date of final sanction of pension, whichever is later
Accounts	Schedules to establishment pay bills for the period for which Pay Bill Register is maintained	3 years or one year after completion of audit, whichever is later
Accounts	Acquittance Rolls of pay and allowances (other than travelling allowances)	3 years or one year after completion of audit, whichever is later
Savings Bank	Special error book maintained in the SB Branch	3 years

Savings Bank	Books of preliminary savings bank receipts	3 years from the date of issue of last receipt
Savings Bank	Monthly statistical registers	3 years
Savings Bank	Register of rectification of SB interest	3 years
Savings Bank	Register of deceased depositor's claim cases including files and records	3 years after the accounts are closed except where withdrawals are allowed on an indemnity bond... 6 years....
Savings Bank	Guard book containing applications for the issue of new SB passbooks in lieu of spoilt ones	3 years
Savings Bank	Preliminary receipts NC 4(a) issued for Post Office Savings Certificates	3 years
Savings Bank	Special error book relating to Savings Certificates	3 years
Savings Bank	Monthly statistical registers (Savings Certificates)	3 years
Savings Bank	Invoices of Certificates	3 years
Savings Bank	Monthly Statement of stock position of Certificates sent by the Sub Office to Head Office	3 years
Savings Bank	Claims to postal certificates of deceased holders (all relevant material...)	Three years after payment is made except... 6 years...
Savings Bank	Partially used up Authorised Agents Receipt books	3 years
Miscellaneous	Invoices of articles received from the Stock Depot	3 years
Miscellaneous	Carbonic copies of invoices returned to Stock Depot	3 years

Miscellaneous	Gradation List	3 years after new ones have been issued
Miscellaneous	Correspondence relating to personal files, appointments, nominations, leave, pension and punishments	3 years after the month in which the official concerned ceased to belong to the Department.
Miscellaneous	Personal files	3 years after death/retirement or date of final sanction of pension, whichever is later
Miscellaneous	Register of Post Box Holders (M.23)	3 years
Miscellaneous	Director General's Circulars and general orders...	3 years after following April
Miscellaneous	Postmaster's Order Book	3 years
Miscellaneous	Monthly statistical registers (Est 88, Est 90, Est 91, Est 92 etc)	3 years
Miscellaneous	Monthly statistical abstract	3 years
Miscellaneous	Correspondence register	3 years

Four Years

Branch	Description of Records	Period of Preservation
Accounts	Register of losses, recoverable advances and retrenchments	4 years

Five Years

Branch	Description of Records	Period of Preservation
Accounts	Register of refunds (ACG 27)	5 years
Accounts	Register of Budget grants	5 years
Accounts	Service Rolls	5 years after death, resignation, discharge or retirement whichever is earlier
Accounts	Register of cheque/receipt books	5 years from the date of last entry in the register
Accounts	Life Certificate and Certificate of unemployment obtained from pensioners...	5 years
Accounts	Money order receipts and acknowledgements of pensioners	5 years
Accounts	Bill Register maintained in Form TR.28-A	5 years
Accounts	Muster rolls and Register of muster rolls	5 years
Savings Bank	Specimen signature books - SO	5 years after all the accounts featuring in the books have been closed or transferred
Savings Bank	Register of nomination of SB accounts	5 years after all the accounts finding place in the register and the guard book... are closed/settled
Savings Bank	Guard book containing applications for nomination of SB accounts and applications for cancellation and variation of nomination	5 years after all the accounts finding place in the register and the guard book... are closed/settled
Savings Bank	Guard book containing applications of depositors for revival of silent accounts	5 years (Rule 81 of POSB Manual Vol 1)

Savings Bank	All long books and List of Transactions either available in hard copy or in soft copy	5 years
Savings Bank	All ledger cards or account details... Account Opening Forms with CDD/KYC documents and SS Books	5 years after closure of the account
Savings Bank	All account closure vouchers	5 years from the date of closure of accounts
Savings Bank	All purchase application forms along with KYC/CDD documents	5 years after discharge of certificates
Miscellaneous	Confidential records/character sheets of officials who have retired	5 years after retirement (preserved with pension cases)
Miscellaneous	Attendance Register (S.37)	5 years

Six Years

Branch	Description of Records	Period of Preservation
Accounts	Grain compensation and overtime allowance etc, Bills	6 years
Accounts	Bills for reimbursement of medical charges	6 years
Accounts	Bill of charges for conveyance of mails, etc and payees' receipts for money paid...	6 years
Savings Bank	Guard books containing depositor's applications for duplicate passbooks	6 years
Savings Bank	Applications for purchase of transfer of certificates in lieu of which duplicate certificates have been issued	For a period of 6 years plus the prescribed period of maturity or extended maturity...
Miscellaneous	Confidential records/character sheets of officials.... d) who have been dismissed, removed or compulsorily retired...	6 years (preserved with disciplinary proceedings)

Seven Years

Branch	Description of Records	Period of Preservation
Miscellaneous	Records of appellate proceedings	7 years from the date of disposal of appeal

Ten Years

Branch	Description of Records	Period of Preservation
Bag Account	Day bag books in CBOS	10 years
Bag Account	Stock Register	10 years
Bag Account	Repairable bags register	10 years
Bag Account	Unserviceable bags register	10 years
Sub Accounts	Treasurers Cash Book	10 years
Accounts	Register of Security Deposits or Bonds	10 years
Accounts	Loan Register	10 years
Accounts	File Index Register	10 years
Savings Bank	Nominal roll kept in SB/SC branch	10 years
Savings Bank	Stock register of certificates	10 years after a new register is opened and the Postmaster has initialled the carried forward entries
Savings Bank	Nominal Roll kept in SB and Savings Certificates Branches	10 years
Savings Bank	Nominal Roll kept in SB and Savings Certificates Branches	10 years
Miscellaneous	Stock book	10 years after the year in which it is replaced by a fresh stock book

Miscellaneous	Records of disciplinary proceedings	10 years from the date of disposal of disciplinary case
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23 Years

Branch	Description of Records	Period of Preservation
Savings Bank	Bonds of Indemnity obtained in connection with the issue of duplicate certificates	(i) 5 year NSCS: 23 years from the date of issue

25 Years

Branch	Description of Records	Period of Preservation
Accounts	Register of Files/Vouchers/Registers a) Transferred to Departmental recording Wing...	25 years
Miscellaneous	Confidential records/character sheets of officials c) who have retired on invalid pension	25 years or 3 years after death, whichever is earlier (preserved with pension cases)

35 Years

Branch	Description of Records	Period of Preservation
Accounts	Letter of authority for payment to another person or agent	35 years
Accounts	Annual establishment return (Book of Establishment)	35 years
Accounts	Pay Bill Register	35 years
Accounts	Office copies of establishment pay bills and related schedules (in cases where pay bill register is not maintained)	35 years

Permanent

Branch	Description of Records	Period of Preservation
Accounts	Runner's appointment certificates	Permanent
Accounts	Register for maintaining particulars of accounts records destroyed	Permanent
Accounts	Register of Destruction of records	Permanent
Savings Bank	List of silent accounts received from the SBCO by the sub offices	Permanent
Savings Bank	Ledger Cards of silent accounts and ledger folio of silent accounts extracted	Permanent
Miscellaneous	Nominal Roll	Permanent
Miscellaneous	Register of Destruction of records	Permanent

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